



Creative Ad·Bundance

Static Ads Creative Playbook

How we produce on-brand, performance-ready static ads that clients actually approve — the focus order, the hard rules, and the traps that ruin a batch.

Internal creative + operator reference · Creative Ad·Bundance · v1

1. The one idea behind everything

We do not invent ads from a blank page. We **take a proven concept and re-skin it truthfully for the brand**. Every rule in this document flows from that. A winning ad already solved the hard part — the hook, the layout, the psychology. Our job is to preserve what makes it work and swap in the correct brand, product, and message without breaking it.

The mindset (Eric's rule): When you have a proven performer, you *keep it and adapt it to the objective* — you do not reinvent the angle. The fastest way to lose is to "improve" a winner into something unproven.

So the question "is the focus the headline or the visuals?" has a specific answer: **neither is first**. The first job is getting the *right concept, right product, and right brand* on screen. A beautiful headline on the wrong product is an instant reject. Here is the actual order of priority.

2. Where to focus — the priority stack

When judging or fixing an ad, work top-down. A failure high on this list kills the ad no matter how good everything below it is.

- 1 Concept fidelity**
Is it a clear, single, proven format — and did we stay inside it? One hook, one visual, one CTA. Not a brochure.
- 2 Product & brand truth**
The exact product, exact colorway, real logo, real app screens. Correct brand, never a sister brand. This is the #1 reason a batch gets rejected.
- 3 The hook / headline**
One dominant message. For a winner, keep its proven copy. For a new concept, one sharp benefit- or pain-led hook. Only real facts.
- 4 Visual hierarchy & layout**
Headline largest and readable at thumbnail size; text in clean zones off the product; CTA is the obvious click target.
- 5 Render quality**
Sharp, no blur, no floating objects, correct anatomy, no gibberish text.
- 6 Compliance & truth-in-claims**
Offers and dates verbatim, no invented awards or stats, disclaimers small and correct.

Rule of thumb: A *sparse but true* ad beats a *rich but fabricated* one every time. The same is true of the Brand Brain that feeds it.

3. The three ways we build an ad

Every run is one of three modes. The mode decides how faithfully we copy the source.

Mode	What the source is	How faithful we stay
Hand-picked templates (top performers)	Templates the requester chose from the library (other brands' proven ads).	Borrow the <i>structure</i> , re-map the story to this brand. One ad per pick.
Client winners / references	The brand's own top ad, or a reference they uploaded for this run.	Clone the proven layout closely. If there is an offer, keep the ad and only overlay the promo. Variants change exactly one thing.
Library fallback	Auto-picked library templates when nothing was chosen or uploaded.	Borrow structure, impose our strict one-hook copy.

Borrow the structure, not the story. A picked template keeps its layout, its graphic device (toggle rows, quiz pills, split panel, arch, badge), its typography style and negative space. Everything about *content* — product, copy, logo — becomes this brand's. Never keep an object or scene that has no meaning for the brand.

4. Concept formats — pick ONE, stay inside it

Direct-response statics work because each one commits to a single recognizable format. Mixing two formats in one ad is the fastest way to look amateur. The proven formats we work in:

iOS push notification	Lock-screen mock, app icon, title, body, Skip/CTA.
iOS Notes screenshot	Notes header, title, bulleted checklist, CTA button.
iMessage toggle comparison	Two iOS toggle rows: pain vs solution.
Handwritten / sticky note	Paper texture, marker handwriting, casual.
Whiteboard line-drawing story	"This is [Name]. [Story]." stick figures.
Billboard / out-of-home mock	Product on a real billboard, sky behind.
Customer review screenshot	5-star card, name, review text, optional photo.
Lifestyle hero + feature checklist	Product photo plus 3–4 checkmark bullets.
Bold typography on dark	Large stencil text, single price/claim anchor.
Gift-box reveal	Product emerging from a wrapped present.
Family / UGC testimonial + stickers	Photo, quote bubble, feature stickers.

This is not a brochure. One hook (the headline), one primary visual, one CTA. Do not show three product variants as equal heroes, do not stack five feature icons in a row, do not add a big legal block. If legal text is needed, one 8 pt footer line only.

5. Product & brand truth (the batch-killer)

More rejected batches come from this than anything else. The product on screen must be *the client's real product*, rendered exactly. The rules change by brand type.

Physical-product brands

- Use the **exact product image** — same shape, label, packaging text, and **packaging form** (pouch, bottle, jar, box, tube). If the template shows a different form, discard the template's product and render the real one. Never turn a pouch into a jar.
- Reproduce **every colorway**. If the winning ad shows a stack of grey, white, light-blue and green towels, the new ad shows that same multi-color stack — never collapse it to one color.
- Never swap in a look-alike product from the model's imagination. Never alter label copy, ingredient lists, or product names.

Digital / app brands

Their "products" are **real app screenshots**, not packaging. Composite the actual screens into a clean phone mockup as the hero. Reproduce the screen exactly — invent no UI, buttons, charts, numbers, or text. Ignore every packaging rule: there is no box or bottle. If several screens are supplied, show a small set (hero + 1–2 supporting) or pick the one that fits the concept — never merge screens into one fake screen.

Service / B2B brands

- No physical product, so never stamp the brand name onto random objects (cups, bags, signs).
- Represent the *outcome*: a clean workspace, documents, a professional environment.

Logo

- Composite the **exact logo file** — never redraw, retype, or approximate the wordmark. Same logo on every ad in a batch. One placement only.
- No logo on file? Render the brand name once as clean plain type in the logo zone — same simple treatment on every ad.

Brand isolation

An ad is for one brand only. Never pull products, packaging, colors, or cues from a sister brand or parent company (e.g. a brand under a portfolio must not borrow a sibling's look). The supplied product images and logo are the *only* identity sources.

6. Headlines & copy

Copy is focus #3 — powerful, but only after the concept and product are right. The discipline:

Element	Spec
Headline	4–7 words, Title Case, the single dominant hook. Rendered largest.
Subline	8–14 words, sentence case, supports the headline directly.
CTA	3–5 words, action-driven button text.
Total text	Max 3 text elements — unless the format (Notes, review, iMessage) needs its own structure.

The non-negotiables

- **On a proven winner, keep the copy.** Reproduce the winning ad's headline and subline word-for-word. Do not write a new angle on a winner — that turns a tested ad into an untested one.
- **Only real facts.** Use dates, prices, percentages, and stats *only* if they appear in the brief or Brand Brain. Never invent or change a number.
- **Never restamp a date.** A "Wirecutter 2024" badge stays 2024. Do not move a sale year onto an award or press mention.
- **No em dashes** in visible ad text. Use commas or colons.
- Every visible word is a real, intentional word — no gibberish.

7. Visual hierarchy & layout

- The headline is the **largest** element and must read when the ad is shrunk to a 200 px thumbnail.
- Hierarchy: **headline > subhead > CTA > legal**. The CTA is the obvious click target, not the fourth step in a flow.
- Text sits in clean, aligned zones (a tidy top band or clear negative space) with balanced margins. Do not float, tilt, or scatter text.
- Keep all text **off the product and off any badge** — no collisions.
- Senior-audience personas: scale body text ~20% larger.

8. Render quality

- Sharp and crisp — every element razor-clear. No blur, soft focus, or compression mush; do not bury the product in heavy background blur.
- No floating objects: everything rests on a surface or is held logically. Realistic shadows and reflections.
- If a person appears: correct anatomy (right count of fingers, eyes, limbs), and shown **using or wearing the product in context** — never underwear/lingerie or styling that ignores the product.
- Icons are clean and vector-style, sharp at full size.

9. Promotions & offers

When the objective is a promo, the winner stays and the offer is added — we do not rebuild the ad around the discount.

Keep-and-overlay (a proven ad + an offer)

- Keep the ad exactly — same concept, hook, imagery, product, layout, existing copy.
- Add **one** promo callout (banner, badge, ribbon) with the offer and dates *verbatim*, framed as limited-time (the deadline must be visible, e.g. "Ends July 27"). Change nothing else.

Promo variants (single-variable tests on a winner)

Each variant changes exactly one thing — the scene — and keeps the message, logo, and typography identical. The four archetypes:

Image swap	Same message, the exact product re-staged in one fresh on-brand scene.
UGC in-context	One person naturally using the product; authentic natural-light feel.
Offer-led urgency	The one variant where the offer is the headline: "SITEWIDE SALE", discount huge, deadline under it.
Limited-time banner	Offer strip + the proven headline + the exact product.

State the offer **once**, cleanly (e.g. "LIMITED TIME SITEWIDE SALE / 20% OFF / Ends July 27"). Never paste the raw brief sentence, never show it twice, never round or extend a date. Award badges are optional — do not force a Wirecutter badge onto every creative.

10. The Brand Brain feeds all of it

Every ad is only as good as the brand record behind it. One record per brand holds the tone, personas, offer, pain points, guidelines, colors, fonts, dos/don'ts, competitors, winning concepts, and losing patterns. It now lives in Supabase (we retired the Airtable version after it hit its record and monthly-API limits).

- **Fill from the real source** — the Creative Brief and Onboarding deck — never from guesswork. A field with no evidence is left empty, not invented.
- **Sister brands map to a parent** where they share a record (e.g. Onsen / GIR / Miracle Made resolve under their portfolio parent). Aliases make the lookup forgiving of spelling.
- **Fonts and colors are real brand assets.** The headline must render in the brand's actual typeface — if the brand's headline face is a serif, it must be that serif, never a default sans.

11. The Creative Director review gate (mandatory)

Nothing ships without a human pass. Eric's non-negotiable checks:

- **Label truth** — the product label/packaging is the real one, not a hallucinated variant, and no invented third-party packaging (no fake snack boxes, no blank competitor jugs).
- **Hand & body anatomy** — correct where a person appears.
- **Product / box scale** — the product sits at a believable size in the scene.

An automated QA pass scores each render 1–10 and flags issues before you even look, but it assists the human gate — it does not replace it. Flags it raises:

logo_distorted logo_missing duplicate_logo packaging_wrong text_garbled fake_text floating_objects
broken_anatomy text_too_small weak_hierarchy color_off_brand disclaimer_missing hallucinated_elements

12. Do / Don't quick reference

DO

- Start from a proven concept and adapt it.
- Render the exact product, colorway, and packaging form.
- Composite the real logo file, one placement.
- Keep a winner's copy word-for-word.
- Commit to one concept format per ad.
- One hook, one visual, one CTA.
- Put the offer in verbatim, with the deadline visible.
- Use the brand's real fonts and colors.
- Show people using the product in context.
- Leave a field empty when there's no evidence.

DON'T

- Reinvent the angle of a proven winner.
- Swap in a look-alike product or wrong colorway.
- Treat an app screenshot as physical packaging.
- Redraw or retype the logo from memory.
- Invent or change any date, price, or stat.
- Restamp an award/press year with the sale year.
- Mix two concept formats in one ad.
- Stack 5 feature icons or 3 equal hero products.
- Float text over the product or add a big legal block.
- Pull assets or colors from a sister brand.

13. Failure modes we've hit (and the fix)

Symptom	Real cause	Fix
Every ad has the same headline (e.g. "Find Your Solution")	The copy AI call failed and fell back to a hardcoded default. Usually a rotated/dead API key or a bad model id.	Confirm the copy service key is live; watch the surfaced copy_error ; the fallback now uses real brand data, not a generic line.
Right concept, wrong product / one flat color	The exact product/colorway wasn't given as truth, so the model invented one.	Attach the exact product image; on a winner, let the winning ad itself be the product truth (don't override with a mismatched packshot).
App shown as a bottle/box	A digital brand's screenshots were treated as physical packaging.	Digital-brand handling: composite the real screens into a phone, no packaging rules.
The picked template layout isn't respected	Image model mismatch — the prompt is written for positional multi-image compositing.	Render with nano-banana-pro (template + product + logo by position), not a model that blends references loosely.
One or two junk ads with a broken source	A picked template URL 404'd (gallery out of sync with the library).	Dead template URLs are now dropped before building.
Twice as many ads as requested	Manual picks generated 2 variants each.	One ad per hand-picked template.
"Nothing saved / results don't match"	The flow was run only to the first node in the editor and never reached the save step.	Trigger the full flow end-to-end, not a single-node test.

14. Pre-flight checklist

Before you trust a batch:

- ☐ The client resolves to the right Brand Brain record (parent or sister name).
- ☐ Fonts, colors, and logo are present and correct for that brand.
- ☐ Product truth is set: exact product image (physical), app screenshots (digital), or outcome scene (service).
- ☐ Generation mode matches intent (hand-picked vs winners/references vs library).
- ☐ Every picked template URL resolves.
- ☐ The copy service is live (spot-check one ad's headline is written, not the fallback).
- ☐ Any offer in the brief is copied verbatim, deadline included.
- ☐ Aspect ratio matches the platform field on the form.
- ☐ Ran the full flow — outputs are actually saved.
- ☐ Human CD gate: label truth, anatomy, product scale.

15. Technical guardrails (for the operator)

Setting	Value / rule
Image model	<code>nano-banana-pro</code> on KIE. Images field is <code>image_input</code> (array). Add <code>resolution: 2K</code> , <code>output_format: png</code> .
Input images per ad	Max 8 : template first, then product/screenshots, logo last.
Prompt length	KIE cap is 10,000 chars; we clamp the build to ~9,400 to leave room for the copy block.
Aspect ratio	Follows the platform field on the intake form (e.g. Square 1:1), not the brief text.
Templates & Brand Brain	Both in Supabase (public-read). Airtable retired after hitting record + monthly-API limits.
Copy & QA models	Run through OpenRouter. If copy fails after a key rotation, update the key in both the copy node and the QA node.

The whole playbook in one line: Start from something proven, put the *real* brand and product on it exactly, say one true thing loudly, and let a human check it before it ships.

Creative Ad-Bundance — Static Ads Creative Playbook. Internal reference; captures the working rules and the fixes learned in production.